

Chapter | 16 | The Job Search



>>> Chapter Objectives

In this chapter, students will

- Be introduced to resources for learning about career opportunities
- Learn to write effective job application letters
- Learn to format résumés that emphasize their strengths
- Learn to prepare for successful job interviews
- Read and analyze model job application letters and résumés

In applying for a job, you are selling yourself. It is no time for either self-delusion or false modesty. You must first assess your abilities, then find an appropriate job match, and finally, persuade a potential employer that you are the right one for the job.

This chapter offers suggestions for landing a job in your profession, but these suggestions will also be

useful if you are applying for an internship. You'll find information on these main activities:

- Researching occupations and companies
- Writing job letters and résumés
- Succeeding in job interviews

>>> Researching Occupations and Companies

Before writing a job letter and résumé, you may need information about (1) career fields that interest you (if you have not already chosen one), (2) specific companies that hire graduates in your field, and, obviously, (3) specific jobs that are available. Following are some pointers for finding such information—both from traditional sources and from your computer.

>> Do Basic Research in Your College Library or Placement Office

Libraries and placement centers offer one starting point for getting information about professions. Following are a few well-known handbooks and bibliographies found in reference collections. They either give information about occupations or provide names of other books that supply such information:

Career Choices Encyclopedia: Guide to Entry-Level Jobs

Dictionary of Occupational Titles

Directory of Career Training and Development Programs

Encyclopedia of Business Information Sources

Encyclopedia of Careers and Vocational Guidance

High-Technology Careers

Occupational Outlook Handbook

Professional Careers Sourcebook: An Information Guide for Career Planning

You can also check online sources such as careeroverview.com.

You should also take advantage of services provided by your college placement office. Many placement offices offer services like reviews of résumés, job announcement lists, workshops, job fairs, and mock interviews.



>> Build a Network of Professionals in Your Field

Networking is one of the most useful approaches to learning about your field, and the contacts that you make can become excellent resources in your job search. Although networking may lead to an invitation to interview for a job, that is not its main purpose. Instead, you are developing relationships with colleagues and learning about current issues in your professional field. Informal and formal networking opportunities are everywhere. Just be prepared to take advantage of them.

- **Casual networks:** You already have a network of friends and family, but look for other ways to build connections. For example, volunteering with community organizations can put you in touch with members of your local business community. Although these networks are not directly related to your career, you may learn of opportunities through people you meet in these informal settings.
- **Professional networks:** Attend regular meetings of professional organizations, and introduce yourself to others at the meetings. Converse with them in a relaxed manner, listening to what they have to say. As a conversation is winding down, ask for one of their business cards, and offer business cards of your own. Also carry a pen so that you can make notes on the back of the business cards you collect. Remember that these meetings, although professional, are still somewhat casual and are not the place for determined job hunting. You can mention that you are looking for a job, but don't press for job interviews or offer your résumé.
- **Online networks:** Discussion lists and social networking sites for professionals are a good way to make initial contact with others in your field. Look for discussion lists that are sponsored by professional organizations such as the Society for Technical Communication and professional networking sites such as LinkedIn. When you join an online group or networking service, take time to learn about it. Read the organization's Web site, especially the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs). Consider *lurking*, or simply reading messages on the list for a while, to get a feel for the kinds of topics discussed and the level of formality of the posts. You should also think about your online presence in other social media (such as FaceBook). Even if you think you have clearly separated your professional and personal online lives, be aware that many employers search the Internet for information about potential employees, including posts they have made to discussion lists, pages they maintain on social networking sites, and posts to Web sites, and blogs.

If someone in your network lets you know about a job opportunity, make sure to thank her or him for the referral (an e-mail is fine). If the referral results in a job offer, consider following up with a handwritten note.

>> Interview Someone in Your Field of Interest

To get the most current information, arrange an interview with someone working in an occupation that interests you. This abundant source of information often goes untapped by college students, who mistakenly think such interviews are difficult to arrange. In fact, you can usually locate people to interview through (1) your college placement office,

(2) your college alumni association, (3) your college major adviser, or (4) your own network of family and friends. Another possibility is to call a reputable firm in the field and explain that you wish to interview someone in a certain occupation. Make it clear, however, that you are not looking for a job—only information about a profession.

Once you set up the interview, prepare well by listing your questions in a notebook or on a clipboard that you take with you to the interview. This preparation keeps you on track and shows persons being interviewed that you value their time and information. Following are some questions to ask:

- How did you prepare for the career or position you now have?
- What college course work or other training was most useful?
- What types of activities fill your typical working day?
- What features of your career do you like the most? The least?
- What personality characteristics are most useful to someone in your career?
- How would you describe the long-term outlook of your field?
- How do you expect your career to develop in the next 5 years, 10 years, or 15 years?
- Do you know any books, periodicals, or online sources that might help me find out more about your field?
- Do you know any individuals who, like you, might permit themselves to be interviewed about their choice of a profession?

Although this interview may lead to a discussion about job openings in the interviewer's organization, the main purpose of the conversation is to retrieve information about an occupation.

>> Find Information on Companies in Your Field

With your focus on a profession, you can begin screening companies that employ people in your chosen field. First, determine the types of information you want to find; examples include location, net worth, number of employees, number of workers in your specific field, number of divisions, types of products or services, financial rating, and names and titles of company officers. The following are some sources that might include such information. They can be found in the reference sections of libraries and in college placement centers.

The Career Guide gives overviews of many American companies and includes information such as types of employees hired, training opportunities, and fringe benefits.

Corporate Technology Directory profiles high-tech firms and covers topics such as sales figures, number of employees, locations, and names of executives.

Facts on File Directory of Major Public Corporations gives essential information on 5,700 of the largest U.S. companies listed on major stock exchanges.

Job Choices in Science and Engineering, an annual magazine published by the College Placement Council, includes helpful articles and information about hundreds of companies that hire technical graduates.

Peterson's Business and Management Jobs provides background on employers of business, management, and liberal arts graduates.

Peterson's Engineering, Science, and Computer Jobs provides background information on employers of technical graduates.

Standard & Poor's Register of Corporations, Directors, and Executives lists names and titles of officials at 55,000 public and private U.S. corporations.

>> Do Intensive Research on a Selected List of Potential Employers

The previous steps help get you started finding information on occupations and firms. Ultimately, you will develop a selected list of firms that interest you. Your research may have led you to these companies, or your college placement office may have told you that they had job openings. Now you must conduct an intensive search to learn as much as you can about the firms. Following are a few sources of information, along with the kinds of questions each source helps answer.

- **Annual reports** (often available at company Web sites and in your library or placement office): How does the firm describe its year's activities to stockholders? What are its products or services?
- **Web sites or media kits** (available online or from public relations offices): How does the firm portray itself to the public? What can you infer about the firm's corporate culture?
- **Personnel manuals and other policy guidelines:** What are features of the firm's *corporate culture*? How committed is the firm to training? What are the benefits and retirement programs? Where are its branches? What are its customary career paths?
- **Graduates of your college or university now working for the firm:** What sort of reputation does your school have among decision makers at the firm?
- **Company newsletters and in-house magazines:** How open and informative is the firm's internal communication?
- **Business sections of newspapers and magazines:** What kind of news gets generated about the firm?
- **Professional organizations or associations:** Is the firm active within its profession?
- **Stock reports:** Is the firm making money? How has it done in the past five years?
- **Accrediting agencies or organizations:** How has the firm fared during peer evaluations?
- **Former employees of the company:** Why have people left the firm?
- **Current employees of the company:** What do employees like, or dislike, about the company? Why do they stay?

Other good sources include the Better Business Bureau, Chamber of Commerce, and local newspapers. In other words, you should thoroughly examine an organization from the outside. The information you gather helps you decide where to apply and, if you later receive a job offer, where to begin or continue your career.

>> Use Your Computer to Gather Data

Today, many applicants go directly to the computer to find information about professions, organizations, graduate schools, and job openings. No doubt between the time this book is written and then published, the names and number of online resources will change dramatically. Generally, some of the information available includes the following:

- College and university catalogs
- Web sites for companies, organizations, and schools
- Employment listings from local and national sources
- Online discussion forums involving recent graduates of colleges and universities

There are a number of job search sites available on the Internet. The following list is current, as of this writing:

America's Career InfoNet, www.acinet.org
CareerBuilder, www.careerbuilder.com
College Grad Job Hunter, www.collegegrad.com
Jammin' Jobs, www.jamminjobs.com
Monster, www.monster.com
NationJob Network, www.nationjob.com

At many of these sites, you can

1. Get tips on writing your résumé and searching for jobs
2. Post your résumé at the site, in multiple forms for varied employers
3. Peruse lists of job openings
4. Receive advice from professionals who are in the career you wish to pursue
5. Read in-depth reports on particular companies
6. Share comments with other job seekers

In other words, the Internet helps you locate a variety of information during your job search. Moreover, you can use your computer to search for openings and respond to job ads, as mentioned in the next section.

>>> Job Correspondence

Job letters and résumés must grab the attention of busy readers, who may spend only 60 seconds deciding whether to consider you further. This section gives you the tools to write a successful letter and résumé. *Successful*, of course, means a letter and résumé that get you an interview. After that, your interpersonal skills help you land the job. The letter and résumé only aim to get you to the personal interview.



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Most job letters and résumés are still sent through the mail. However, a growing number of applicants use the Internet to apply for jobs.

For example, online services can place résumés in a bank used by hundreds and perhaps thousands of companies. The résumés are scanned with software that searches for keywords that reflect abilities needed for specific jobs. The program then sends selected résumés to companies. If you use this kind of service, remember one point: When you send credentials into cyberspace, you cannot be sure where they will land. Do not expect the level of confidentiality and security that you have with personal mail.

Whether you use online techniques like e-mail and résumé services or stick with the traditional approach, the same basic writing guidelines apply. Your letter, no longer than one page, should be specific about the job you seek and your main selling points. Then the résumé—one page or two at most—should simply, specifically, and neatly highlight your background.

Job Letters

A job letter is just another type of sales letter—except that you are selling yourself, not a product or service. In preparing to write one, take the point of view of the persons to whom you are writing. What criteria will they use to evaluate your credentials? How much or how little will they want in the letter? What main points are they hunting for as they scan your résumé? This section first examines the needs of these readers and then gives guidelines for you, the writer. Models 16–1 through 16–4, on pages 622–629, include sample job letters and résumés.

The Readers' Needs

You probably will not know personally the readers of your job letter, so you must think hard about what they may want. Your task is complicated by the fact that often there are several readers of your letter and résumé who may have quite different backgrounds.

One possible scenario follows:

- Step 1:** The letter may go first to the personnel office, where a staff member specializing in employment selects letters and résumés that meet the criteria stated in the position announcement. (Some large employers may even store letters and résumés in a computer, where they are scanned for keywords that relate to specific jobs.)
- Step 2:** Applications that pass this screening are sent to the department manager who will supervise the employee who is hired. The manager may then select a group to be interviewed. This manager interviews applicants and ultimately hires the employee.

One variation of this process has the personnel department doing an interview as well as screening letters and résumés—before the department manager even hears about any applications. Another variation, as noted earlier, has the employer relying on an online résumé service for the initial screening.

Yet sooner or later, a supervisor or manager reads your letter and résumé. And most readers, whatever their professional background, have the following five characteristics in common:

>> **Feature 1: They Read Job Letters in Stacks**

Most search-and-screen processes are such that letters get filed until there are many to evaluate. Your reader faces this intimidating pile of paper, from which you want your letter to emerge as the victor.

>> **Feature 2: They Are Impatient**

Your readers expect major points to jump right out at them. In most cases, they will not dig for information that cannot be found quickly.

>> **Feature 3: They Are Tired**

Some employment specialists may save job letters for their fresher moments, but many people who do the hiring get to job letters at the end of a busy day or at home in the evening, so they have even less patience than usual for flowery wording or hard-to-read typeface.

>> **Feature 4: They Become Picky Grammarians**

Readers of all professional and academic backgrounds expect good writing when they read job letters. There is an unspoken assumption that a letter asking for a chance at a career will reflect solid use of the language. Furthermore, it should have no typographical errors. If the letter does contain a typo or grammar error, the reader may wonder about the quality of writing you will produce on the job.

>> **Feature 5: They Want Attention Grabbers but Not Slickness**

You want your letter and résumé to stand out without the use of gimmicks. Most readers prefer a tasteful and reserved format that does not draw too much attention to itself. For example, white or off-white stationery is still the standard, along with traditional fonts with lots of white space for easy reading. If you want to attract attention in a professional manner, consider attaching a business card to your letter so that the reader has your name and number handy. Students can design and print business cards with software available in many college computer labs.

Of course, likes and dislikes vary. An advertising director, who works all day with graphics, may want a bolder format design than an engineering manager, who works with documents that are less flashy. If you cannot decide, it is best to use a conservative format and style.

ABC Format: Job Letters

- **ABSTRACT:** Apply for a specific job
 - Refer to ad, mutual friend, or other source of information about the job
 - Briefly state how you can meet the main need of your potential employer
- **BODY:** Specify your understanding of the reader's main needs
 - Provide your main qualifications that satisfy these needs (but only highlight points from your résumé—do not simply repeat all résumé information)
 - Address specific qualifications mentioned in a job announcement
 - Discuss skills or experience listed on the résumé that are directly related to the job announcement
 - Avoid mentioning weak points or deficiencies
 - Keep body paragraphs to six or fewer lines
 - Use a bulleted or numbered list if it helps draw attention to three or four main points
 - Maintain the “you” attitude throughout
- **CONCLUSION:** Tie the letter together with one main theme or selling point, as you would a sales letter
 - Refer to your résumé
 - Explain how and when the reader can contact you for an interview

The Letter's Organization

The job letter guidelines that follow relate to the features mentioned about readers. Your one and only goal is to tantalize the reader enough to want to interview you—that is all. With that goal and the reader's needs in mind, your job letter should follow the ABC format on the left.

This pattern gives you a starting point, but it is not the whole story. There is one feature of application letters that cannot be placed easily in a formula—style. Work hard with your draft to develop a unity and flow that, by itself, sets you apart from the crowd. Your attention grabber engages interest, but the clarity of your prose keeps readers attentive and persuades them that you are an applicant who should be interviewed.

Résumés

Résumés usually accompany application letters. Three points make writing résumés a challenge:

1. **Emphasis:** You should select just a *few major points of emphasis* from your personal and professional life. Avoid the tendency to include college and employment details best left for the interview.
2. **Length:** You usually should use only *one page*. For individuals with extensive experience, a two-page résumé is acceptable—if it is arranged evenly over both pages.
3. **Arrangement:** You should arrange information so that it is *pleasing to the eye and easy to scan*. Prospective employers

spend less than a minute assessing your application. They may even use computers to scan résumés, taking even less time.

Computers pose a special challenge to you as a résumé writer because they fail to appreciate some of the elegant variations and innovations sometimes used to get the human reader's attention. If you are writing a résumé that may be read by a computer, you may want to (1) use white or very light-colored paper, (2) focus on keywords—especially job skills—that might be picked up by the computer scan, and (3) avoid design features that might present obstacles to the scan, such as italics, fancy typefaces, and graphics like those in Model 16–7, on page 632. Actually, you may find that your placement office uses a computer résumé program that requires a particular format, effectively removing decisions about style from your consideration.

You may also need to format a résumé that can be copied and pasted into forms for online applications. Such résumés should be saved as text files (.txt). It is a good idea to

create this kind of résumé in Notepad or a similar program on your computer. Avoid using tabs, italics, bolding, bullets, or other special characters, as these do not translate to the text file. (For an example of a résumé formatted to be submitted online, see Model 16–6, on page 631.)

This section distills the best qualities of many formats into three basic patterns:

1. The chronological résumé, which emphasizes employment history
2. The functional résumé, which emphasizes the skills you have developed
3. The combined résumé, which merges features of both the chronological and the functional formats. (See the “Experience” section that follows to learn when to use each format. Choose the pattern that best demonstrates your strengths.)

The following paragraphs describe the main parts of the résumé. The “Experience” section explains the differences between chronological, functional, and combined résumés. Refer to the models on pages 622–632 for résumé examples.

Objective

Personnel directors, other people in the employment cycle, and even computers may sort résumés by the statement of your objective. Writing a good objective is hard work, especially for new graduates, who often just want a chance to start working at a firm at any level. Despite this eagerness to please, do not make the mistake of writing an all-encompassing statement such as “Seeking challenging position in innovative firm in civil engineering field.” Your reader will find such a general statement of little use in sorting your application. It gives the impression that you have not set clear professional goals.

Most objectives should be short, preferably one sentence. Also, they should be detailed enough to show that you have prepared for, and are interested in, a specific career, yet open-ended enough to reflect a degree of flexibility. If you have several quite different career options, you might want to design a different résumé for each job description, rather than trying to write a job objective that takes in too much territory.

Note: Some employers prefer that you not include an objective. For example, you may be applying for an entry-level job, for which an objective would be inappropriate. As always, consider your reader’s needs as you make decisions about objectives.

Education

Whether you follow the objective with the “Education” or the “Experience” section depends on the answer to one question: Which topic is most important to the reader? Most recent college graduates lead off with “Education,” particularly if the completion of the degree prompted the job search.

This section seems simple at the outset. Obligatory information includes your school, school location, degree, and date of graduation. It is what you include beyond the bare details, however, that most interests employers. Following are some possibilities:

- **Grade point average:** Include it if you are proud of it; do not if it fails to help your case.



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- **Honors:** List anything that sets you apart from the crowd—such as dean’s list or individual awards in your major department. If you have many, include a separate “Recognitions” heading toward the end of the résumé.
- **Minors:** Highlight any minors or degree options, whether they are inside or outside your major field. Employers place value on this specialized training, even if (and sometimes especially if) it is outside your major field.
- **Key courses:** When there is room, provide a short list of courses you consider most appropriate for the kind of position you are seeking. Because the employer probably will not look at your transcripts until a later stage of the hiring process, use this brief listing as an attention grabber.

Experience

This section poses a problem for many applicants just graduating from college. Students often comment that experience is what they are looking for, not what they have yet. Although you haven’t begun your professional career, you may have experience that can help you stand out as a job candidate. Consider experience such as training and scheduling other employees or balancing cash registers and entering information about bank deposits. You should also include leadership positions in campus organizations, such as organizing fund-raising activities. Experience like this shows employers that you are responsible and professional.

Depending on the amount of work experience you have gained, consider three options for completing this section of the résumé: (1) emphasize specific positions you have held (chronological résumé), (2) emphasize specific skills you have developed in your experience (functional résumé), or (3) emphasize both experience and skills (combined résumé).

Option 1: Chronological Format

This option works best if your job experience has led logically toward the job you now seek. Models 16–1 and 16–2 on pages 622–625 include examples of chronological résumés that meet these guidelines:

- List relevant full-time or part-time experience, including internships, in reverse chronological order.
- Be specific about your job responsibilities while still being brief.
- Be selective if you have had more jobs than can fit on a one-page résumé.
- Include nonprofessional tasks (such as working on the campus custodial staff) if it helps your case (e.g., the employer might want to know that you worked your way through college).

- Remember that if you leave out some jobs, the interview will give you the chance to elaborate on your work experience.
- Select a readable format with appropriate white space.
- Use action verbs and lists to emphasize what you did or what you learned at jobs—for example, “Provided telephone support to users of System/23.” Use parallel form in each list.

Option 2: Functional Format

This approach works best if (1) you wish to emphasize the skills and strengths you have developed in your career rather than specific jobs you have had, or (2) you have had “gaps” in your work history that would be obvious if you used the chronological format. Although the functional format is sometimes used by those whose job experience is not a selling point, this is not always the case. Sometimes your skills built up over time are the best argument for your being considered for a position, even if your job experience is also strong. For example, you may have five years’ experience in responsible positions at four different retailers. You then decide to write a functional résumé focusing on the three skill areas you developed: sales, inventory control, and management. Models 16–3 and 16–4 on pages 626–629 include functional résumés.

If you write a functional résumé that stresses skills, you may still want to follow this section with a brief employment history (see Option 3). Most potential employers want to know where and when you worked, even though this issue is not a high priority. *Note:* If you decide to leave out the history, bring it with you to the interview on a separate sheet.

Option 3: Combined Format

The combined format uses features of both chronological and functional formats. This format works best when you want to emphasize the skills you have developed while still giving limited information on the chronology of your employment.

Models 16–5 and 16–6 on pages 630–631 show two variations of the combined format. Model 16–5 integrates chronological information into the skills section. The positions held may not be prestigious, but together they show that the applicant has considerable experience developing the two sets of skills listed: Editing/Writing and Teaching/Research. In Model 16–6, the experience section looks exactly as it would in a functional résumé, with subheadings giving the names of skills. However, the writer adds a brief skeleton work history near the end of the page; she believes the reader will want some sort of chronological work history, even if it is not the writer’s strength.

Activities, Recognitions, and Interests

Most résumés use one or two of these headings to provide the reader with additional background information. The choice of which, if any, to use depends on what you think best supports your job objective. Following are some possibilities:

- **Activities:** Selected items that show your involvement in your college or your community or both.

- **Recognitions:** Awards and other specific honors that set you apart from other applicants. (Do not include awards that might appear obscure, meaningless, or dated to the reader, such as most high-school honors.)
- **Interests:** Hobbies or other interests that give the reader a brief look at the “other” you.

However you handle these sections, they should be fairly brief and should not detract from the longer and more significant sections described previously.

References

Your résumé opens the door to the job interview and later stages of the hiring process, when references will be called. There are two main approaches to the reference section of the résumé:

1. Writing “Available upon request” at the end of the page
2. Listing names, addresses, and phone numbers at the end of the résumé or on a separate page

The first approach assumes that the reader prefers the intermediate step of contacting you before references are sent or solicited. The second approach assumes that the reader prefers to call or write references directly, without having to contact you first. Use the format most common in your field or, most important, the one most likely to meet the needs of a particular employer. As always, be ready to tailor your letter and résumé each time you put it in the mail.

Your goal is to write an honest résumé that emphasizes your good points and minimizes your deficiencies. To repeat a point made at the outset, you want your résumé and job letter to open the door for later stages of the application process. Look on this writing task as your greatest persuasive challenge. Indeed, it is the ultimate sales letter, for what you are selling is the potential you offer to change an organization and, perhaps, the world as well. Considering such heady possibilities, make sure to spend the time necessary to produce first-rate results.

>>> Job Interviews

Your job letter and résumé have only one purpose: to secure a personal interview by the personnel director or other official who screens applicants for a position.

Much has been written about job interviews. Fortunately, most of the good advice about interviewing goes back to just plain common sense about dealing with people. Following are some suggestions to show you how to prepare for a job interview, perform at your best, and send a follow-up letter.

Preparation

>> Do Your Homework on the Organization

You have learned how to locate data about specific companies. Once you have been selected for an interview, review whatever information you have already gathered about the employer, and then go one step further by searching for the most current

information you can find. Your last source may be someone you know at the organization or a friend of a friend.

When you don't have personal contacts, use your research skills again. For large firms, locate recent periodical or newspaper articles by consulting general indexes—such as the *Business Periodicals Index*, *Wall Street Journal Index*, *Readers' Guide to Periodicals*, *New York Times Index*, or the index for any newspaper in a large metropolitan area. For smaller firms, consult recent issues of local newspapers for announcements about the company. Being aware of current company issues demonstrates your initiative and shows your interest in the firm.

As noted earlier, the company's Web site can also be a good source of current information about an organization.



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>> Prepare Portfolio Materials, If Appropriate for the Position

Portfolios have become important in a variety of career fields. They are expected of technical communicators, but if you have created projects of any type as part of your major, you may be asked to submit a portfolio. Later in your career, you may find that designing and writing documents, Web sites, and other material have become an important part of your job, and that a portfolio will help display your skills.

Whether you are officially asked to submit a portfolio or not, having one available can help distinguish you from other job candidates, and it offers an opportunity to show off your writing, design, and software skills. Your portfolio should start with a copy of your résumé. It should also include five or six projects that you have created. Each project should have a cover sheet that briefly explains the information listed below. If you have created proprietary or other private materials during an internship or for your job, do not include those materials in your portfolio.

- **Brief description:** What kind of document is the project (e.g., a report, a Help file)? Was the project created as a class assignment, for a client, or for a campus or community organization?
- **Audience:** Who was the project created for? What special audience concerns did you take into account when you created the project?
- **Skills:** What special skills or abilities does the project illustrate? Does it show your ability to write procedural documents? To conduct and present research? To use a software tool? To design graphics? Basically, explain what the project shows about you as a technical communicator.

If you are creating a print portfolio, use consistent design and formatting throughout the portfolio, especially in the project cover sheets. Look for ways to use design elements such as color or simple graphics to create a portfolio that is a unified document. Put your

portfolio in a nice notebook or portfolio folder, and take it to interviews with you. When the interviewer asks about your projects, you can offer to share your portfolio. You can offer to send a copy of portfolio items later, or you can have a copy of your portfolio burned onto a CD-ROM to offer interviewers.

Providing a digital version of your portfolio is especially important if you have digital documents such as bookmarked PDFs, Help files, instructional videos, or Web pages. You can burn a digital portfolio on a CD-ROM, and you can also make your portfolio available as a Web site, like the ones in Model 14–1 on pages 560–561 and Model 14–2 on pages 562–564. Like print portfolios, digital portfolios should have a unified look and feel on all pages. Using templates or a cascading style sheet for your Web site will help maintain a uniform look throughout a Web site. (For more on creating Web sites, see Chapter 14.) Web sites that present digital portfolios usually have three levels and four types of pages.

- **Level 1: The home page (index page).** This is the first page that viewers will access. It should set the tone for your Web site. It may include a personal statement about your qualifications and your goals. It must include links to your résumé and to the introduction pages for each of the projects in your portfolio. This page should be formatted in HTML.
- **Level 2: Résumé page and project cover pages.** Save your résumé as a PDF. Different computers have different settings for styles. Even the “normal” text style in Microsoft Word may vary from one computer to the next. To ensure that the résumé someone else sees (and prints) is exactly the one you created, save your résumé as a PDF. Your cover pages for your projects should each include a link to the project that they describe. Web pages formatted in HTML usually are best for pages that include links, but it is possible to put links in PDFs if you have the right software. If the project requires special software to access, such as Flash Player or Adobe Reader, include this information and a link to where the software may be downloaded.
- **Level 3: Project pages.** Your projects should be saved in a format that can be opened by any reader. People reading your portfolio may not have access to the same document design, graphic, or video software that you used to create your project, so save the project in the format most easily accessed by most of your readers.

>> Write Out Answers to the Questions You Consider Likely

You should not take written answers with you to the interview, but writing them out in advance will give you a level of confidence unmatched by candidates who only ponder possible questions that might come their way, without writing them out. This technique resembles how some people prepare for oral presentations: First, they write out a speech, then they commit it to notes, and finally, they give an extemporaneous presentation that reflects confidence in themselves and knowledge of the material. This degree of preparation places you ahead of the competition.

There are few, if any, original questions asked in job interviews. Most interviewers simply select from some standard questions to help them find out more about you and your background. Following are some typical questions, along with tips for responses:

1. **Tell me a little about yourself.** Keep your answer brief and relate it to the position and company—do not wander off into unrelated issues, like hobbies, unless asked to do so.
2. **Why did you choose your college or university?** Be sure your main reasons relate to academics—for example, the academic standing of the department, the reputation of the faculty, or the job placement statistics in your field.
3. **What are your strengths?** Focus on two or three qualities that would directly or indirectly lead to success in the position for which you are applying.
4. **What are your weaknesses?** Choose weaknesses that if viewed from another perspective, could be considered strengths—for example, your perfectionism or overattention to detail.
5. **Why do you think you would fit into this company?** Using your research on the firm, cite several points about the company that correspond to your own professional interests—for example, the firm may offer services in three fields that relate to your academic or work experience.
6. **What jobs have you held?** Use this question as a way to show that each previous position, no matter how modest, has helped prepare you for this position—for example, part-time employment in a fast-food restaurant developed teamwork and interpersonal skills.
7. **What are your long-term goals?** Be ready to give a 5- or 10-year plan that, preferably, fits within the corporate goals and structure of the firm to which you are applying—for example, you may want to move from the position of technical field engineer into the role of a project manager, to develop your management skills.
8. **What salary range are you considering?** Avoid discussing salary if you can. Instead, note that you are most interested in criteria such as job satisfaction and professional growth. If pushed, give a salary range that is in line with the research you did on the career field in general and this company in particular.
9. **Do you like working in teams or prefer working alone?** Most employers want to know that you have interest and experience in teamwork—whether in college courses or previous jobs, but they also admire and reward individual accomplishment. In deciding what part of your background to emphasize, consider the corporate culture of the organization interviewing you.
10. **Do you have any questions of me?** Always be ready with questions that show further your interest in the organization and your knowledge of the position—for example, “Given the recent opening of your Tucson warehouse, do you plan other expansions in the Southwest?” or “What types of in-house or off-site training do you

offer new engineers who are moving toward project management?” Other questions can concern issues such as (a) benefits, (b) promotions, (c) type of computer network, and (d) travel requirements.

>> Do Mock Interviews

You can improve your chances considerably by practicing for job interviews. One of the easiest and best techniques is role playing. Ask a friend to serve as the interviewer and give him or her a list of questions from which to choose. Also, inform that person about the company so that he or she can improvise during the session. This way, you are prepared for the real thing.

You can get additional information about your interviewing abilities by videotaping your role-playing session. Reviewing the videotape helps you highlight (1) questions that pose special problems for you and for which you need further preparation and (2) mannerisms that need correction. This preparation technique is especially useful if you are one of the growing number of applicants who take part in a video interview with a recruiter.

>> Be Physically Prepared for the Interview

Like oral presentations, job interviews work best when you are physically at your best; therefore, all the old standbys apply:

- Get a good night's rest before the interview.
- Avoid caffeine or other stimulants.
- Eat about an hour beforehand so that you are not distracted by hunger pangs during the session.
- Take a brisk walk to dispel nervous energy.

Performance

Good planning is your best assurance of a successful interview. Of course, there are always surprises that may catch you. Remember, however, that most interviewers are seriously interested in your application and want you to succeed. Help them by selling yourself and thus giving them a reason to hire you. Following are some guidelines for the interview:

>> Dress Appropriately

Much has been written on the topic of appropriate attire for interviews. Some practical suggestions that are often emphasized include:

- Dress conservatively and thus avoid drawing attention to your clothing—for example, do not use the interview as an opportunity to break in a garment in the newest style.
- Consider the organization—for example, a brokerage firm interview may require a dark suit for a man and a tailored suit for a woman, whereas an interview at a construction firm may require less formal attire.

- Avoid excessive jewelry.
- Pay attention to the fine points—for example, wear shined shoes and carry a tasteful briefcase or notebook.

>> Take an Assertive Approach

Either directly or indirectly, use everything you say to make the case for your hiring. Be positive, direct, and unflappable. Use every question as a springboard to show your capabilities and interest, rather than waiting for point-blank questions about your qualifications. To be sure, the degree to which you assert yourself partly depends on your interpretations of the interviewer's preference and style. Although you do not want to appear pushy, you should take the right opportunities to sell yourself and your abilities.

>> Use the First Few Minutes to Set the Tone

What you have heard about first impressions is true: Interviewers draw conclusions quickly. Having given many interviews, they are looking for an applicant who injects vitality into the interview and makes their job easier. Within a minute or two, establish the themes and the tone that will be reinforced throughout the conversation—that is, your relevant background, your promising future, and your eagerness (not pushiness). In this sense, the interview subscribes to the preacher's maxim mentioned in Chapter 15: "First you tell 'em what you're gonna tell 'em, then you tell 'em, and then you tell 'em what you told 'em."

>> Maintain Eye Contact While You Speak

Although you may want to look away occasionally, much of the time your eyes should remain fixed on the person interviewing you. This way, you show interest in what she or he is saying.

If you are being interviewed by several people, make eye contact with all of them throughout the interview. No one should feel ignored. You are never quite certain exactly who may be the decision maker in your case.

>> Be Specific in the Body of the Interview

In every question, you should see the opportunity to say something specific about you and your background. For example, rather than simply stating that your degree program in computer science prepared you for the open position, cite three specific courses and briefly summarize their relevance to the job.

>> Do Not Hesitate

A job interview is no time to hesitate, unless you are convinced the job is not for you. If the interviewer notes that the position involves travel 40 percent of the time, quickly respond that the prospect of working around the country excites you. The question is this: Do you want the job or not? If you do, then accept the requirements of the position and show excitement about the possibilities. You can always turn down the job if you receive an offer and decide later that some restrictions, like travel, are too demanding.

>> Reinforce Main Points

The interviewer has no text for the session other than your résumé; therefore, you should drive home main points by injecting short summaries into the conversation. After a 5-minute discussion of your recent work experience, take 15 seconds to present a capsule version of relevant employment. Similarly, orchestrate the end of the interview so that you have the chance to summarize your interest in the position and your qualifications. Here is your chance to follow through on the “Tell ‘em what you told ‘em” part of the preacher’s maxim.

Follow-up Letters

Follow every personal contact with a letter or e-mail—whatever is most appropriate—to the person with whom you spoke. Send it within 24 hours of the interview or meeting so that it immediately reinforces the person’s recollection of you. This simple strategy gives you a powerful tool for showing interest in a job.

Follow-up letters abide by the same basic letter pattern discussed in Chapter 6. In particular, follow these guidelines:

- Write no more than one page.
- Use a short first paragraph to express appreciation for the interview.
- Use the middle paragraph(s) to (a) reinforce a few reasons why you would be the right choice for the position or (b) express interest in something specific about the organization.
- Use a short last paragraph to restate your interest in the job and to provide a hopeful closing.

See Chapter 6 for the various formats appropriate for all types of business letters. A sample thank-you letter follows:

Dear Ms. Ferguson:

I enjoyed meeting with you yesterday about the career possibilities at Klub Kola’s district headquarters. The growth that you are experiencing makes Klub an especially exciting company to join.

As I mentioned, my marketing background at Seville College has prepared me for the challenge of working in your new Business Development Department. Several courses last semester focused specifically on sales strategies for consumer goods. In addition, an internship this semester has given me the chance to try out marketing strategies in the context of a local firm.

Again, thank you for the chance to learn about your firm’s current success and promising future. I remain very interested in joining the Klub Kola team.

Sincerely,
Marcia B. Mahoney

When your audience might appreciate a less formal response, consider writing your interviewer a personal note instead of a typed letter. This sort of note is most appropriate when you plan a short message.

>>> Chapter Summary

- College Libraries can provide basic information about career opportunities and professional fields.
- College placement offices can help students find job opportunities and prepare for job interviews.
- Networking is a valuable tool in professional development. Students should cultivate the informal networks that they already have, such as family and friends, and they should build more formal networks through professional organizations and online groups.
- Interviews with professionals and research on companies can provide important information for the job search.
- Effective job application letters take into account the needs of the reader.
- The ABC format provides a clear organization for application letters and résumés.
- Résumés should include information about the applicant's career objectives, education, experience, and appropriate activities, recognitions, and interests. They may include a list of references or offer to make references "available upon request".
- Résumés may use a chronological format, a functional format, or a combined format.
- Prepare for a job interview by learning about the organization, writing out answers to possible interview questions, and practicing beforehand.
- Portfolios allow technical communicators to demonstrate their abilities through sample projects.
- During an interview, present a professional image, be assertive, and offer specific answers to questions.
- Follow up an interview with a thank you letter.

>>> Learning Portfolio

Communication Challenge 20-Something—Have Degree, Won't Travel

Zach Lipkowski has been out of Mountain State College for almost a year and is still looking for his first real job. In the meantime, he has become a part-time ski instructor and worked in construction. With the help of a cheap apartment and a loan from his parents, he is managing to cover his bills, but he certainly hasn't used his biology degree from Mountain State. Now he finally has a break, having learned about an opening at M-Global's Denver office. This case study describes Zach's background. It ends with questions and comments for discussion and an assignment for a written response to the Challenge.

A Checkered College Career

At Mountain State, Zach majored in biology, a field that had interested him since childhood and that he thought promised a good career. His boyhood hobby of studying poison arrow frogs kindled his interest in the life sciences. It also led to a field trip to the Costa Rican rain forest in high school with a Denver biological group. He even helped a well-known frog expert on a study, providing the Denver researcher with observations about the exotic frogs Zach kept as pets at home. So biology was a good fit.

In the first couple years of college, Zach considered many career options. Perhaps he could enter veterinary or medical school, or he might do research for industry or the government in environmental science. Another possibility was graduate school in biology toward a teaching career. By the time he was a junior, however, it was clear his grades probably were not high enough for him to get into medical or vet school or a Ph.D. program in biology. He graduated with a 2.5 overall and a 2.9 in his major—respectable, but not stellar. Some low grades in subjects like math, history, and English had hurt his average.

Despite some mediocre grades, he had the chance to work on an interesting senior project in which he studied microbe digesters, organisms used to clean up pollution sites by converting toxins into nontoxic substances through the chemical digestive process. Although only one member of a six-person team, he helped place microbes and then gather data at the site—a paper mill with toxic water. A team member who was a graduate student actually wrote most of the report, but Zach helped draft the summary of fieldwork. His modest part in the project had further inspired his hands-on interest in biology.

Zach Meets the Job Market—Twice

Although Zach did not seem destined to inhabit the ivy-covered walls of graduate school, he thought he would have a good shot at entry-level jobs in environmental science, and he was right. He applied for many environmental science openings and got two good offers, both in the Midwest.

After much thought he turned down both offers, wanting to stay in Colorado because his mother was ill and, frankly, because he had always wanted to work in Colorado for his career. He was confident that an opportunity would open up as the Denver job market improved. When his mother recovered from her illness, Zach started working in August for a small construction firm as a day laborer, stopping for several months to work at a ski resort. He also took off a month for the trip he had always dreamed about—a fishing and canoeing venture to British Columbia.

By May, a year after graduation, he was regretting not having taken one of the job offers a year earlier. Most of his college friends were working in their fields, even if only at modest jobs, yet he was still doing the same kind of work he had done during summers in college. So Zach decided to reapply for entry-level jobs in environmental consulting firms. These jobs would involve the following main tasks: (1) visiting sites that needed environmental remediation, (2) overseeing lab tests, (3) forming conclusions and recommendations based on these tests, (4) writing reports that summarize activities, and (5) writing proposals and giving presentations to seek new work.

An Offer Brings Self-Assessment

This week, Zach's college placement center called him about an opening for an environmental scientist at M-Global's Denver office. He planned to send a job letter and résumé and hoped for a chance to interview.

Taking the advice of a placement specialist at his alma mater, Zach evaluated his skills, abilities, and experience before writing his new letter and résumé. He jotted down these basic points about his background, some of which were detailed previously:

Positive

- Has good work ethic
- Has long-time interest in applied biology
- Took four-course sequence in environmental science—two courses short of a minor in the field

- Enjoys outdoors and travel
- Worked on microbe project in college, helping to write report

Neutral or Negative

- Did not take professional position after college
- Had mediocre college grade point average
- Focused more on straight biology than on applied environmental science
- Got a C in a required technical writing course
- Had no outstanding extracurricular activities—study, part-time work in the dining hall, and “winding down” seemed to take up most of his time

Questions and Comments for Discussion

Put yourself in Zach’s shoes. As he prepares for the job application process, what advice would you give him on the following issues? Refer to the guidelines in the chapter in formulating your answers.

1. This chapter cites specific goals for cover letters. What should Zach emphasize in his letter to M-Global?
2. Zach plans to submit a one-page résumé with his letter. What format should he select? Why?

3. Reread Zach’s list of positive and neutral or negative features. Do you agree with his self-assessment? What features of his background will be of most concern to M-Global? Why? What can Zach do to reduce the impact of negative items in his background during the entire application process?
4. Specifically, how should Zach deal with (a) his mediocre grade point average and (b) the year he has spent doing work unrelated to his intended profession?
5. If his letter and résumé interest M-Global, Zach will interview with Ken Pierson, an M-Global project manager who knows very little about biology or microbes. His field is geology. Yet he manages projects that use the talents of a wide range of scientists, engineers, and technicians. What advice would you give Zach to make the best possible impression during the interview?

Write About It

Assume the role of Zach. Write a one-page letter of application addressed to Carl Jensen, Director of Human Resources for the Denver branch of M-Global. Find ways to present negatives (such as Zach’s year of experiences since graduation) as strengths.

Collaboration at Work Planning for Success

General Instructions

Each Collaboration at Work exercise applies strategies for working in teams to chapter topics. The exercise assumes you (1) have been divided into teams of about three to six students, (2) will use time inside or outside of class to complete the case, and (3) will produce an oral or written response. For guidelines about writing in teams, refer to Chapter 3.

Background for Assignment

Some students attend college for its own sake because they love learning; others may like to learn but mainly view college as a stepping-stone to a career. Because most students are in the second group, they give a good deal of thought to what they will do with their working lives. If they don’t, they should. Achieving success in a career starts with establishing a careful plan for getting from here to there. It is a process that involves considerably more than gaining a degree.

Team Assignment

For this exercise, you and your team members must brainstorm about a strategy for getting a particular job or entering a particular career desired by one of your team’s members. (You can do the exercise for several careers, if you have time.) Following are the three steps:

1. Share information about the ideal jobs of all team members.
2. Choose one position or career that best fits the assignment (i.e., one that lends itself to being achieved in an incremental process that is doable).
3. Generate a list of specific steps for getting the position or entering the career (include deadlines and criteria for success at each stage).

If you have time to conduct some research and have access to the Internet, go to one of the Web sites listed on page 603 in this chapter for assistance in your research.

Assignments

Assignments can be completed either as individual exercises or as team projects, depending on the directions of your instructor. Your instructor will ask you to prepare a response that can be delivered as an oral presentation for discussion in class. Analyze the context of each Assignment by considering what you learned in Chapter 1 about the context of technical writing, and answer the following questions:

- What is the purpose of the document to be written?
- What result do you hope to achieve by writing it?
- Who are your readers and what do they want from your document?
- What method of organization is most useful?

1. Analysis: Job Announcement

Find a job advertisement in the newspaper, on the Internet, or at your college placement office. The ad should match either qualifications you have now or those you plan to have after you complete the academic program on which you are now working. Read the ad carefully and make a list of the required and recommended qualifications for the job. Write a brief statement of how you meet as many of the qualifications as possible.

2. Analysis: Potential Employer

Search Web sites of organizations where you might apply for a job to find one that lists job openings on its site. Briefly answer the following questions: (1) How do you apply for jobs with the organization? (2) What information does the Web site offer about the organization's mission? If the organization has an opening in a position that you are eligible for or will be when you graduate, note the qualifications and responsibilities listed.

3. Analysis: Job Search Site

Search one of the job-posting sites listed on page 603 for jobs in your field. Write a brief tutorial for searching the site, including information about how to choose keywords for a search in your field and how to use the advanced search features of the Web site.

Follow these general guidelines for the Practice assignments:

- Print or design a letterhead when necessary.
- Use whatever letter, memo, or e-mail format your instructor requires.
- Invent addresses when necessary.

- Invent any extra information you may need for the correspondence, but do not change the information presented here.

4. Practice: Job Letter and Résumé

Find a job advertisement in the newspaper, on the Internet, or at your college placement office. The ad should match either qualifications you have now or those you plan to have after you complete the academic program on which you are now working. Write a job letter and résumé that respond to the ad. Submit the letter, résumé, and written advertisement to your instructor.

If useful for this assignment and if permitted by your instructor, you may fictionalize part of your résumé so that it lists a completed degree program and other experience not yet acquired. This way, the letter and résumé reflect the background you would have if you were applying for the job. Choose the résumé format that best fits your credentials.

As an alternative, write a letter and résumé to apply for an internship in your major field. To find out about internships, contact your department or campus internship director, or ask about internships at your college placement office.

5. Practice: Job Search Portfolio

Create a print or digital portfolio that you can use for internship or job applications. Include a résumé, four to six projects, and cover pages for each project. Use elements of document design throughout the portfolio to create an attractive, cohesive document that demonstrates your abilities as a writer and designer and your skills with software tools. Your instructor may encourage you to include projects such as software programs you have written, equipment schematics you have created, or papers that you have written for classes in your major field.

6. Practice: Job Interview

Pair up with another classmate for this assignment. First, exchange the letters, résumés, and job ads referred to in Assignment 1. Discuss the job ads so that you are familiar with the job being sought by your counterpart, and vice versa. Then perform a role-playing exercise during which you act out the two interviews, one person as applicant and the other as interviewer.

Option:

Include a third member in your team. Have this person serve as a recorder, providing an oral critique of each interview at the end of the exercise. Then collaborate among the

three of you in producing a written critique of the role-playing exercise. Specifically, explain what the exercise taught you about the main challenges of the job interview.

7. Practice: Follow-up Letter

After the interview in Assignment 2, write a follow-up letter to the interviewer.

8. Practice: Follow-up Letter—M-Global Projects

Last month, you submitted a job letter and résumé for a position with the Barlow Group in Dallas, Texas. Now the firm has written to express interest in your application. It wants to know more about some summer employment you mentioned on your résumé—the project you worked on was similar to some of Barlow's projects.

Assume the summer work in question was as student-in-training on one of the projects described in Model 12–6 on pages 472–478. Write a letter that briefly describes the project and your participation in it. Use information from the project, along with invented details about the activities you completed as an assistant. Even if your tasks were not especially glorified—manual labor or office support, for example—strive to describe learning experiences that would be meaningful to your reader. You are writing Daniel C. Yates, Barlow Consulting Group, 600 Industrial Way, Dallas, TX 75221.

? 9. Ethics Assignment

Searching for employment presents job seekers with some ethical challenges. A few “ethically challenged” individuals paint the portrait in their résumé of someone who only remotely resembles the real thing. Certainly, lying and deception occur, but most writers simply want to present what they have accomplished and learned in the best possible light. As this chapter suggests, the writing of a résumé is no time to be overly modest. With the goal of supportable self-promotion in mind, evaluate the degree to which the following résumé entries are accurate representations of the facts that follow them.

- a. **Résumé Entry:** June–September 2011—Served as apprentice reporter for a Detroit area weekly newspaper.

Reality: Worked for a little over three months as a fact checker for a group of reporters. Was let go when the assistant editor decided to offer the apprentice position to another, more promising individual with more journalistic experience.

- b. **Résumé Entry:** July 2010—Participated in university-sponsored trip to Germany.

Reality: Flew to Germany with two fraternity brothers for a two-day fraternity convention in Munich, after

which the three of you toured Bavaria for a week in a rental car.

- c. **Résumé Entry:** Summer 2010, 2011, 2012—Worked for Berea Pharmacy as a stock clerk, salesperson, and accountant.

Reality: Helped off and on with the family business, Berea Pharmacy, during three summers while in college—placing merchandise on shelves, working the cash register, and tallying sales at the end of the day. Your father had regular help so you were able to spend at least half of each summer camping with friends, playing in a softball league, and retaking a couple of college courses.



10. International Communication Assignment

There are many opportunities to work abroad, whether in internships, through a contracting firm, or through direct hiring. Using a Web site for a professional organization in your major field or a Web site such as <http://www.goabroad.com/intern-abroad>, find an overseas internship or employment opportunity that interests you. Research and write a report on the cultural practices of the country in which the internship or employment is located. Your instructor will indicate whether your report will be oral or written. Information can be acquired from sources such as the following:

- Faculty and students who have visited the country
- Internet sites on other nations and on international communication
- Friends and colleagues familiar with the country you have chosen
- Books and articles on international communication and working overseas



11. A.C.T. N.O.W. Assignment (Applying Communication To Nurture Our World)

The purpose of this assignment is to assist members of the college or university community who want help writing job letters and résumés. It is a team assignment. First, use this chapter or any other source gathered by your team members to establish a short set of written guidelines for job correspondence. (Be sure to acknowledge sources on the document you prepare.) Second, meet with your instructor to review the guidelines document, making sure all members of your team have a good grasp of the material. Third, submit the document for consideration for publication in the campus newspaper, human resources newsletter, or similar campus publication.

201 Edge Drive
Norcross PA 17001
March 14, 2012

Mr James Vernon Personnel Director
M-Global Inc
105 Halsey Street
Baltimore MD 21212

Dear Mr. Vernon:

My academic adviser, Professor Sam Singleton, informed me about an electrical engineering opening at M-Global, where he worked until last year. I am writing to apply for the job.

I understand that M-Global is making a major effort to build a full-scale equipment development laboratory. That prospect interests me greatly because of my academic background in electrical engineering. At Northern Tech, I took courses in several subjects that might be useful in the lab's work—for example, microprocessor applications, artificial intelligence, and fiber optics.

Also, related work at Jones Energy & Automation, Inc., has given me experience building and developing new electronics systems. In particular, my work as an assembler taught me the importance of precision and quality control. I'd like the opportunity to apply this knowledge at M-Global.

Personal business will take me to Baltimore April 8–10. Could you meet with me on one of those days to discuss how M-Global might use my skills? Please let me know if an interview would be convenient at that time.

Enclosed is a résumé that highlights my credentials. I hope to be talking with you in June.

Sincerely,
Donald Vizano

Donald Vizano

Enclosure: Résumé

Donald Vizano
201 Edge Drive
Norcross PA 17001
(300) 555-7861
dvizano@nct.edu

OBJECTIVE: A full-time position in electrical engineering, with emphasis on designing new equipment in automation and microprocessing

EDUCATION: 2006–2012 Bachelor of Science in Electrical Engineering (expected June 2012)
 Northern College of Technology,
 Shipley, PA 3.5 GPA (out of 4.0 scale)

Major Courses:

Fiber Optics	Artificial Machine Intelligence
Automated Manufacturing Systems	Communication Control Systems
Microprocessor Control	Microcomputer Applications
Microcomputer Systems	Digital Control Systems
	Semiconductor Circuits and Devices

Related Courses:

Information Systems	Programming Languages
Business Communication	Engineering Economy
Industrial Psychology	Technical Communication

Other Skills: Fluent in Spanish

ACTIVITIES

AND HONORS: Institute of Electrical and Electronic Engineering (IEEE)
 Dean's List, eight quarters.

EMPLOYMENT:

2008–2012	Electronic Assembler (part time) Jones Energy & Automation, Inc. Banner, PA
2007–2008	Lab Monitor (part time) Computer Services Northern College of Technology Shipley, PA

REFERENCES: Available upon request

1523 River Lane
Worthville OH 43804
August 6, 2012

Mr Willard Yancy
Director, Automotive Systems
XYZ Motor Company, Product Development Division
Charlotte NC 28202

Dear Mr. Yancy:

Recently I have been researching the leading national companies in automotive computer systems. Your job ad in the July 6 *National Business Employment Weekly* caught my eye because of XYZ's innovations in computer-controlled safety systems. I would like to apply for the automotive computer engineer job.

Your advertisement notes that experience in computer systems for machinery or robotic systems would be a plus. I have had extensive experience in the military with computer systems, ranging from a digital communications computer to an air-traffic-control training simulator. In addition, my college experience includes courses in computer engineering that have broadened my experience. I am eager to apply what I have learned to your company.

My mechanical knowledge was gained from growing up on my family's dairy farm. After watching and learning from my father, I learned to repair internal combustion engines, diesel engines, and hydraulic systems. Then for five years I managed the entire dairy operation.

With my training and hands-on experience, I believe I can contribute to your company. Please contact me at 614/555-2731 if you wish to arrange an interview.

Sincerely,



James M. Sistrunk

Enclosure: Résumé

James M Sistrunk
jmsistrunk@tmail.com
1523 River Lane
Worthville OH 43804
(614) 555-2731

Professional Objective:

To contribute to the research, design, and development of automotive computer control systems

Education:

B.S., Computer Engineering, 2009–present
Columbus College, Columbus, Ohio

Major concentration in Control Systems with minor in Industrial Engineering. Courses included Microcomputer Systems, Digital Control Systems, and several different programming courses.

Computer Repair Technician Certification Training,
2006–2007

U.S. Air Force Technical Training Center,
Keesler Air Force Base, Biloxi, MS

General Computer Systems Option with emphasis on mainframe computers. Student leader in charge of processing and orientation for new students from basic training.

Career Development:

Computer Repair Technician, U.S. Air Force, 2005–2007
Secret Clearance

Responsibilities and duties included:

- Repair of computer systems
- Preventive maintenance inspections
- Diagnostics and troubleshooting of equipment

Accomplishments included:

- “Excellent” score during skills evaluation
- Award of an Air Force Specialty Code “5” skill level

Assistant Manager, Spring Farm, Wootan, Ohio, 2000–2005
Responsible for dairy operations on this 500-acre farm.
Developed management and technical skills; learned to repair sophisticated farm equipment.

Special Skills:

Adobe Creative Suite
Microsoft Word
Object Oriented Languages
C++ Programming

References:

Available upon request

456 Cantor Way #245
Gallop Minnesota 55002
September 3, 2012

Ms Judith R Gonzalez
American Hospital Systems
3023 Center Avenue
Randolf Minnesota 55440

Dear Ms. Gonzalez:

My placement center recently informed me about the Management Trainee opening with Mercy Hospital. As a business major with experience working in hospitals, I wish to apply for the position.

Your job advertisement notes that you seek candidates with a broad academic background in business and an interest in hospital management. At Central State College, I've taken extensive course work in three major areas in business: finance, marketing, and personnel management. This broad-based academic curriculum has provided me a solid foundation for a wide variety of management tasks at Mercy Hospital.

My summer and part-time employment also matches the needs of your position. While attending Central State, I've worked part time and summers as an assistant in the Business Office at Grady Hospital. That experience has acquainted me with the basics of business management within the context of a mid-sized hospital, much like Mercy.

The enclosed résumé highlights the skills that match your Management Trainee opening. I would like the opportunity to talk with you in person and can be reached at 612-555-1111 for an interview.

Sincerely,

Denise Ware Sanborn

Denise Ware Sanborn

Denise Ware Sanborn
sanborndenise@cscm.edu
456 Cantor Way #245
Gallop Minnesota 55002
612-555-1111

Objective

Entry-level management position in the health care industry. Seek position that includes exposure to a wide variety of management and business-related tasks.

Education

Bachelor of Arts Degree, June 2012
Central State College
Gallop, Minnesota

Major: Business Administration
Grade Point Average: 3.26 of possible 4.0, with 3.56 in all major courses
All college expenses financed by part-time and summer work at Grady Hospital in St. Paul, Minnesota.

Skills and Experience**Finance**

- Helped with research for three fiscal-year budgets
- Developed new spreadsheet for monthly budget reports
- Wrote accounts payable correspondence

Marketing

- Solicited copy from managers for new brochure
- Designed and edited new brochure
- Participated in team visits to 10 area physicians

Personnel

- Designed new performance appraisal form for secretarial staff
- Interviewed applicants for Maintenance Department jobs
- Coordinated annual training program for nursing staff

Awards

2012 Arden Award for best senior project in the Business Administration Department (paper that examined Total Quality Management)

Dean's list for six semesters

References

Academic and work references available upon request.

2389 Jenson Court
Gulfton MS 39200
(601) 555-1111
February 18, 2012

Mr Nigel Pierce Personnel Director
Structural Systems Inc
105 Paisley Way
Jackson MS 39236

Dear Mr. Pierce:

I am writing in response to your ad for a technical representative in the July 13 (Sunday) edition of the *Jackson Journal*. I believe my experience in construction and my degree in civil engineering technology make me an excellent candidate for this position.

I am very familiar with your products for the wood construction market. The laminated beams and floor joists your company manufactures were specified by many of the architects I have worked with during my co-op experience at Mississippi College. Work I have done in the residential and small commercial construction industry convinced me of the advantages of your products over nominal lumber.

Enclosed is my résumé, which focuses on the skills gained from my co-op work that would transfer to your firm. I look forward to meeting you and discussing my future with your company.

Sincerely,



Todd L. Fisher

Enclosure: Résumé

Todd L Fisher
2389 Jenson Court
Gulfton MS 39200
(601) 555-1111
tlfish@aol.com

**PROFESSIONAL
OBJECTIVE**

Use my education in civil engineering and my construction experience to assume a technical advisory position.

EDUCATION

Mississippi College
Hart, Mississippi; Bachelor of Science,
Civil Engineering Technology
June 2011, GPA: 3.00 (out of 4.00)

**PROFESSIONAL
EXPERIENCE**

Financed education by working as co-op student for two Jackson construction firms for 18 months.

Design Skills

Assisted with the layout and design of wall panels for Ridge Development condominium project.

Created layout and design for complete roof and floor systems for numerous churches and small commercial projects.

Computer Skills

Introduced computerization to the design offices of a major construction company (HP hardware in HPbasic operating system).

Designed trusses on Sun workstations in the UNIX operating system. Operated as the system administrator for the office.

Leadership Skills

Instructed new computer-assisted design (CAD) operators on the operation of design software for panel layout and design.

Designed and implemented management system for tracking jobs in plant.

REFERENCES

References available upon request.

Karen S Patel

300 Park Drive
 Birtingdale NY 20092
 (210) 555-2112
 KSPatel@tmail.net

OBJECTIVE

Position as in-house technical writer and as trainer in communication skills

EDUCATION**Sumpter College, Marist, Vermont**

M.S. in Technical Communication, GPA: 4.0, December 2011

Warren College, Aurora, New York

M.A. in English, Cum Laude, June 2009

University of Bombay, India

B.A. in English, First Class Honors, June 2005

EMPLOYMENT***Editing/Writing*****Public Relations Office, Sumpter College 2010–present**

Administrative Assistant: Write press releases and conduct interviews. Publish news stories in local newspapers and in *Sumpter Express*. Edit daily campus newsletter.

Hawk Newspapers, Albany, New York, 2007–2008

Warren College Internship: Covered and reported special events; conducted interviews; assisted with proofreading, layout, headline count. Scanned newspapers for current events; conducted research for stories. Published feature stories.

Teaching/Research**Sumpter College, Marist, Vermont, 2010–2011**

Teaching Assistant: Tutored English at the Writing Center, answered “Grammar Hotline” phone questions, edited and critiqued student papers, taught English to non-English speakers, and helped students prepare for Regents exams.

Warren College, Aurora, New York, 2008–2009

Teaching Assistant: Taught business writing, supervised peer editing and in-class discussions, held student conferences, and graded students’ papers.

Research Assistant: Verified material by checking facts, wrote brief reports related to research, researched information and bibliographies.

COMPUTER SKILLS

Microsoft Office, Adobe Creative Suite, Adobe Technical Communication Suite

REFERENCES

Available upon request

SUSAN A MARTIN

SCHOOL ADDRESS

540 Wood Drive
Bama CA 90012
(901) 555-2222

PERMANENT ADDRESS

30 Avon Place
Atlas, CA 90000
(901) 555-6074

E-MAIL

smartin@piercecollege.edu

OBJECTIVE

Analyze and solve problems involving natural and pollution control systems as an Environmental Scientist

EDUCATION

Pierce College, Bama, California
Bachelor of Science, Environmental Science
May 2012, GPA: 3.15 (out of 4.00)
Pleasant Valley College, Barnes, Nevada
Associate in Applied Science, Engineering Science
May 2010, GPA: 3.20 (out of 4.00)

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Research Skills:

- * Worked as lab assistant in a research project to analyze the effect of acid rain on frog reproduction in Lake Lane.
- * Designed Pierce College computer program to analyze data on ozone depletion.

Leadership Skills:

- * Taught inventory procedures to new employees of Zane's Office Supply.
- * Helped incoming freshmen and transfer students adjust to Pierce College as dormitory resident assistant.

Organizational Skills:

- * Maintained academic department files as student assistant in Environmental Science Department.
- * Organized field trips for Pierce College Mountaineering Club.

HONORS AND ACTIVITIES

Dean's list (five semesters)
President of Cycling Club

EMPLOYMENT HISTORY

Dormitory Resident Assistant, Peirce College, Bama, CA 2011-2012
Trainer, Zane's Office Supply, Bama, CA, 2010-2011

REFERENCES

References and transcripts available upon request



Leslie Highland
997 Simmons Drive
Boise Idaho 88822
(208) 555-2233
lnh@btt.net



OBJECTIVE: A full-time position in architectural design with emphasis on model making and renderings for future buildings.

EDUCATION: **Boise Architectural College**
 Boise, Idaho
 Bachelor of Science
 Architectural Engineering Technology
 June 2010

Harvard University
 Cambridge, Massachusetts
 Certificate in Advance Architectural Delineation
 August 2004

ACTIVITIES AND HONORS: **Boise Architectural College**
 Winner of Senior Design Project
 Architectural Engineering Technology
 Charter Member of American Society of
 Architectural Perspectives

EMPLOYMENT:

2004–2010 Architectural Designer and Delineator
 Dorsey-Hudson, Architects
 Boise, Idaho

2002–2004 Architectural Designer and Renderer
 Windsor and Associates, Architects
 St. Lake, Utah

1999–2002 Architectural Renderer and Drafter
 Sanders and Associates, Architects
 Provo, Utah

1997–1999 Architectural Drafter
 Brown Engineering
 St. Lake, Utah

REFERENCES: References and portfolio available upon request.